

THEORY NOTEBOOK

Of Md. Miraz Hossain

A Map of the Field

The core vocabulary of communication study, organised into the three currents that lead to a single contemporary question

MSJ1101: Communication Concepts and Theories

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About This Notebook

This is a theory notebook for the foundational course in communication study, which I took in my first semester. It revisits the field's core concepts — all of them standard, attributed to the thinkers who originated them — and organises them into three currents: how meaning is made, how media shape society, and how power works through communication. The concepts are not mine; the map is. I have arranged them so they lead, deliberately, to the question I now work on as a researcher — the algorithmic feed — because looking back, this is the vocabulary that question is built from.

Why a map and not a list

Communication theory, encountered as a first-year syllabus, arrives as a pile of named models: a diagram from two engineers, a French theory of signs, a few American media-effects studies, a Canadian aphorism about media, some Frankfurt School pessimism. Learned as a list, they are forgettable. The argument of this notebook is that they are not a list but a field with a shape, and that the shape becomes visible the moment you ask what each concept is really a theory of. Some are theories of how meaning gets made between people. Some are theories of how mass media shape the society that consumes them. And some are theories of how power operates through communication. Sorted that way, the canon stops being trivia and becomes a map — one that, read forward, points directly at the systems I study now.

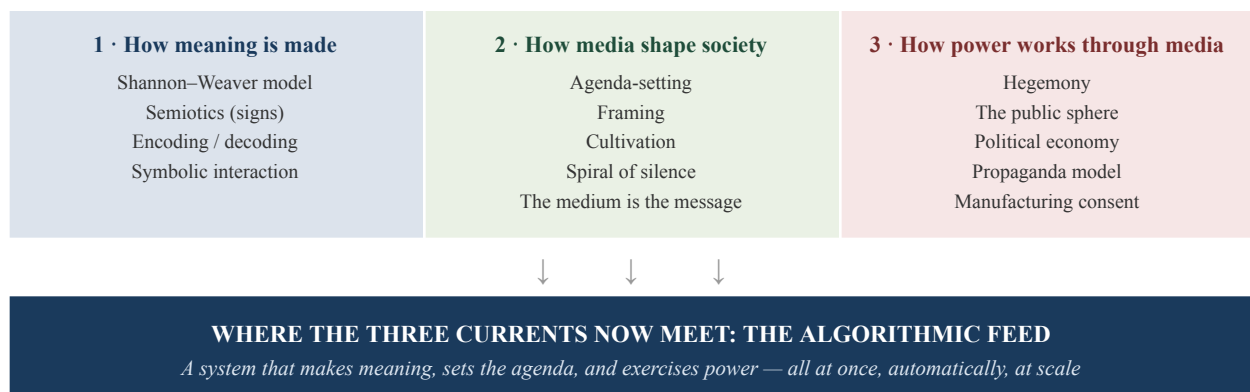
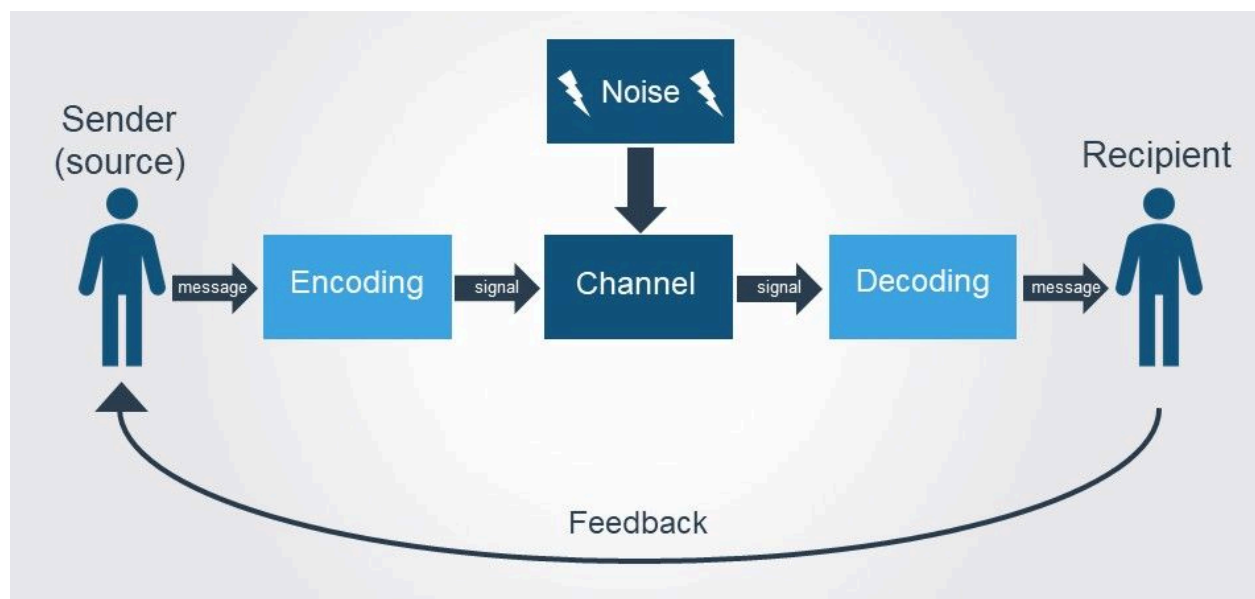


Figure 1. The three currents of communication theory, and the contemporary system where they converge.

CURRENT 1: How meaning is made

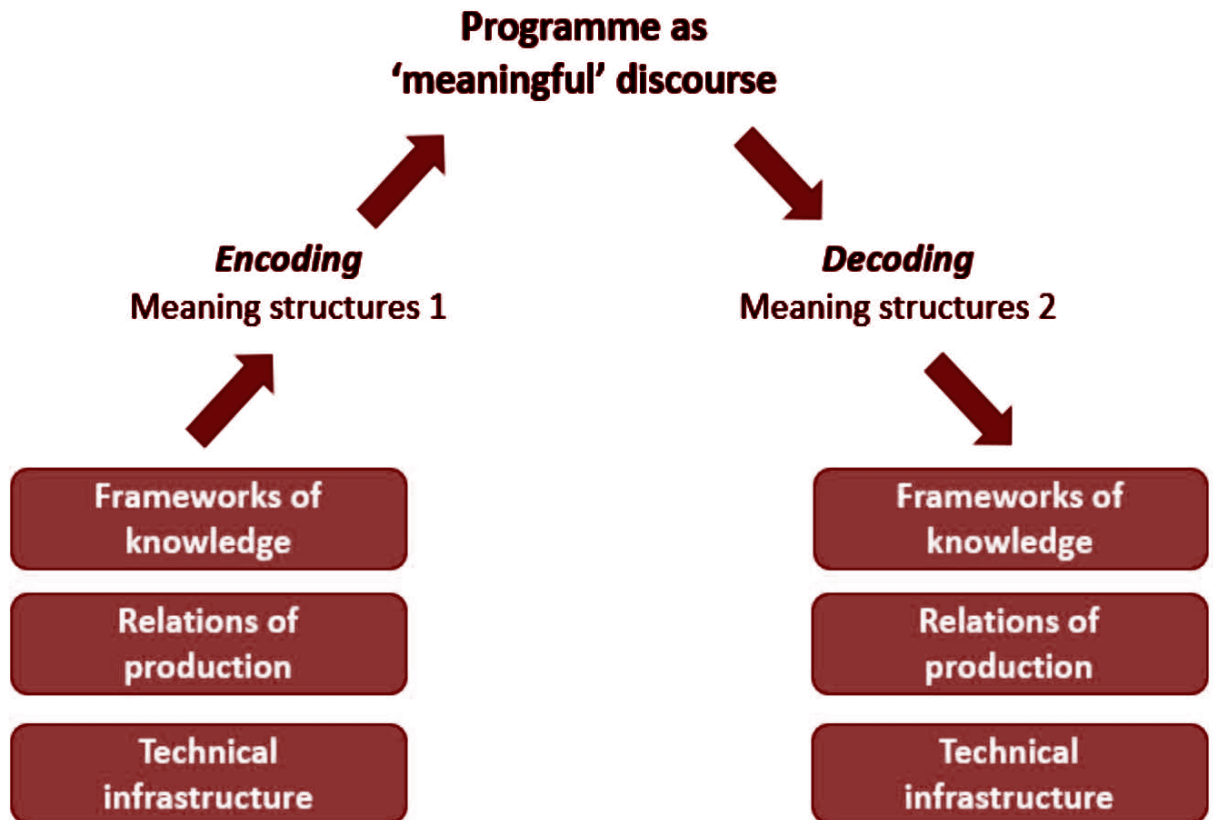
The first current asks the most basic question: how does a message get from one mind to another, and what happens to it on the way? These are the theories of meaning itself.

The Shannon–Weaver model — *Shannon & Weaver, 1949*. The foundational transmission model: a source encodes a message, sends it through a channel to a receiver, and noise interferes along the way. Built for telephone engineering, it gave communication study its first vocabulary — sender, channel, noise, feedback — but also its first limitation, because it treats meaning as a parcel delivered intact rather than something the receiver actively rebuilds.



Semiotics — *Saussure; Peirce; Barthes*. The study of signs and how they signify. A sign is a relationship between a signifier (the word, image, sound) and the signified (the concept it evokes), and the link between them is largely arbitrary and cultural. Barthes extended this to myth — how images and phrases carry a second layer of cultural meaning beneath the literal one. Semiotics is why the same photograph can mean different things to different audiences: meaning lives in the code, not the object.

Encoding / decoding — *Stuart Hall, 1973*. Hall's correction to the transmission model. A media text is encoded with a preferred meaning by its producers, but audiences decode it through their own social position — accepting the preferred reading (dominant), partly resisting it (negotiated), or rejecting it entirely (oppositional). This is the hinge between the meaning current and the power current: it locates interpretation in the audience, but recognises that producers try to steer it.



Symbolic interactionism — *Mead; Blumer*. The view that meaning is produced in social interaction — we act toward things based on the meanings they hold for us, and those meanings are negotiated, not fixed. It grounds communication in the everyday construction of shared reality, and it is the micro-level foundation beneath the larger structural theories that follow.

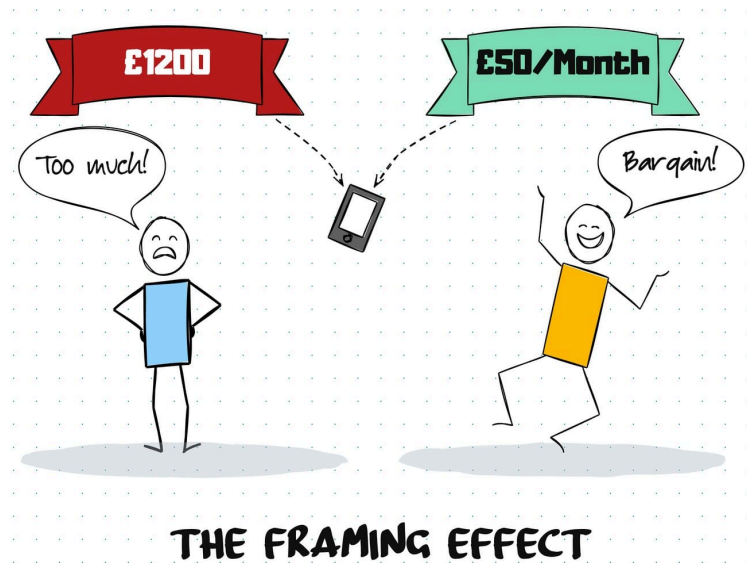
CURRENT 2: How media shape society

The second current moves from the individual message to the mass medium, and asks what sustained exposure to media does to the people and societies that consume it. These are the media-effects and media-environment theories.

Agenda-setting — *McCombs & Shaw, 1972*. Media may not tell us what to think, but they are strikingly successful at telling us what to think about. By choosing which issues to cover and how prominently, news media set the public agenda — the salience of an issue in the public mind tracks its salience in coverage. This is the quiet, structural form of media power: not persuasion, but the prior decision about what is even available to be discussed.

Framing — *Goffman; Entman, 1993*.

Closely related to agenda-setting but one level deeper: not just which issues are covered, but how they are defined. To frame is to select some aspects of a reality and make them more salient — to promote a particular problem definition, causal interpretation, or moral evaluation. The same event framed as ‘crime’ or ‘protest,’ ‘migrant’ or ‘refugee,’ produces different publics.

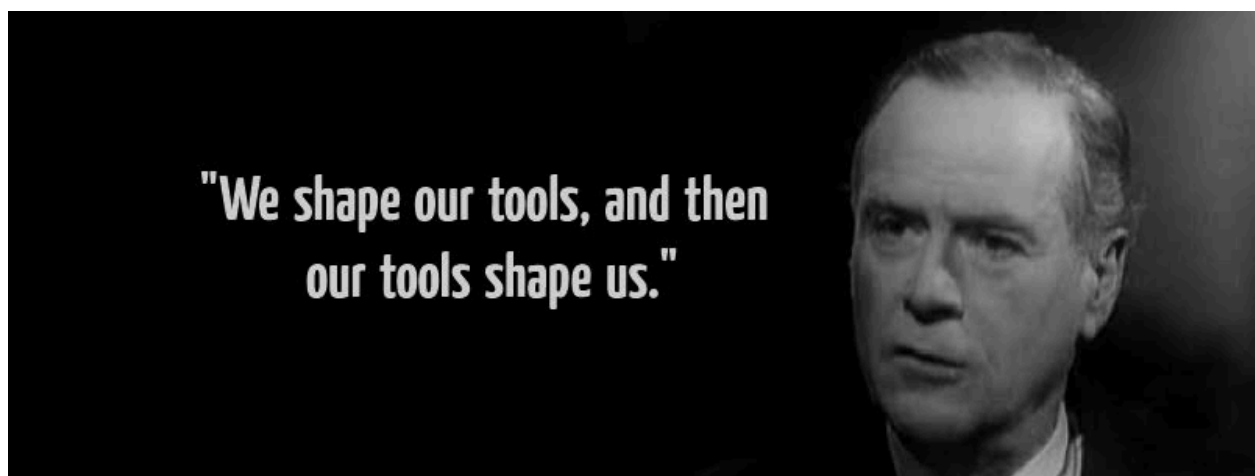


Cultivation theory — *George Gerbner, 1976*. The argument that heavy, long-term exposure to a medium gradually shapes a viewer’s perception of reality toward the medium’s version of it — Gerbner’s ‘mean world syndrome,’ in which heavy television viewers overestimate the prevalence of violence. Cultivation is a theory of slow, cumulative effect, not single-message persuasion, which makes it unusually relevant to anything consumed daily for years.

Spiral of silence — *Noelle-Neumann, 1974*. People who believe their view is in the minority tend to stay quiet for fear of isolation, which makes the perceived majority view look even more dominant, which silences the minority further. Media shape this by signalling which opinions are acceptable. It is a theory of how public opinion can be manufactured through the management of what feels sayable.



The medium is the message — *Marshall McLuhan, 1964*. McLuhan's claim that the form of a medium matters more than any content it carries — that print, television, and the network each restructure human perception and social organisation regardless of what is said through them. Easy to overstate, but indispensable as a reminder that to study communication you must study the medium's architecture, not only its messages.



CURRENT 3: How power works through communication

The third current is the most critical, in both senses. It asks who owns the means of communication, whose interests media serve, and how consent is produced. These are the political-economy and critical theories.

Hegemony — *Antonio Gramsci*. The process by which a dominant group secures rule not mainly through force but through consent — by making its worldview feel like common sense. Media are central to manufacturing that consent, circulating the assumptions that keep an arrangement of power feeling natural and inevitable. Hegemony is why the most effective power is the kind you do not notice operating.

The public sphere — *Jürgen Habermas, 1962*. The idealised space — historically the coffeehouse and the newspaper — where private citizens come together to debate matters of common concern and form public opinion through rational discussion. Habermas's account is partly nostalgic, but it gives communication study its normative yardstick: a healthy democracy needs a functioning public sphere, and much media criticism is an argument that ours is degrading.

Political economy of media — *Murdock & Golding; Smythe*. The analysis of how ownership, advertising, and the profit motive shape what media produce. Smythe's 'audience commodity' thesis — that commercial media sell audiences to advertisers, making the audience the product — is the sharpest version, and the one that reads as eerily prophetic in the platform era.

The propaganda model — *Herman & Chomsky, 1988*. A structural account of how, even without censorship, news passes through a set of filters — ownership, advertising, sourcing, flak, and a unifying ideology — that systematically narrow what gets reported. Its value is the insistence that bias can be structural and impersonal, a property of the system rather than the intent of any individual journalist.

Where the currents meet

Read as three currents, the field resolves into a single trajectory, and the trajectory has a destination the original syllabus could not have named: the algorithmic feed. The feed is where all three currents now converge at once. It is a meaning-making system — it encodes and surfaces messages, and we decode them from our positions, exactly as Hall described. It is a society-shaping system — it sets the agenda by deciding what is visible, frames by ordering and captioning, and cultivates a worldview through years of daily exposure, doing the work of McCombs, Entman, and Gerbner automatically and personally. And it is a power system — owned by a few firms, monetising the audience as commodity exactly as Smythe predicted, manufacturing a kind of consent that Gramsci would recognise and filtering information through a logic Herman and Chomsky would find familiar, now executed by ranking code rather than editorial judgement.

That convergence is the question I work on now: how algorithmically curated feeds relate to what people come to believe, and who is most vulnerable when meaning, agenda, and power are exercised by the same automated system. I did not know that was where this vocabulary led when I first learned it. Mapping it backwards, it could not have led anywhere else. The point of a theory notebook, in the end, is not to memorise the field but to find the question hidden inside it — and to notice that the canon assembled in 1949 and 1972 and 1988 was, all along, describing the machine we would build in 2010 and live inside by now.

Key sources

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